DAY 20 | POST-READ

Ambiguity and Embedded Problem Solving: Recap and Beyond

What we practised today, plus ideas to keep developing.

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Part A: Summary of today

Topic	What to remember
Kinds of ambiguity	Problem, solution, priority, ownership. Each has a different first question.
Problem canvas	Who, what (with an example), impact, success measure. Agreed in writing.
5 whys	Move from symptom to root cause; fix the deepest cause you can.
Issue trees	Break a problem into non-overlapping branches that cover the possibilities.
Hypotheses	State, test with data, decide. Cheapest likely tests first.
Stakeholders	Sponsor, users, IT, security. Meet each early; ask what they care about.
Trust	Listen first, respect constraints, deliver early, share bad news with a plan.
Scope	Written MVP, visible backlog, trade-offs: "yes, and here is what moves".

Part B: Going beyond today

1. MECE thinking

Mutually exclusive, collectively exhaustive: issue tree branches should not overlap and together should cover everything. It keeps analysis complete without double counting.

2. The readout structure

Answer first: the finding in one sentence. Then the evidence (two or three points, each with a number). Then the recommendation and the smallest next step, with an owner and date.

3. Discovery interview tips

- Ask about the past, not the future: "Tell me about the last time this happened."
- Ask to be shown, not told: "Can you share your screen and do it?"
- Stay quiet after a question. People fill silence with the useful detail.

4. Working within constraints

If security forbids sending data to an external service, that is a design input, not an obstacle. Ask what is allowed, and design within it. Constraints often lead to simpler solutions.

5. Handover from day one

FDEs leave eventually. Write runbooks, decision logs and short videos as you go so the customer's team can own the solution after you.

Part C: Reflect

- Which kind of ambiguity do you find hardest, and why?
- Write the 5 whys for a problem from today's simulation.
- Which stakeholder did you understand least in the role plays? What would you ask them next time?
- Rewrite one "no" you said recently as a trade-off.

Part D: Practice ideas for the weekend

- Turn a vague request from your work into a problem canvas.
- Draw an issue tree for "customers are leaving" with at least five branches.
- Explain this week's deployment pipeline to a non-technical friend in under three minutes.

Coming up on Day 21: generative AI: transformers, large language models, mixture of experts, and prompting techniques such as chain of thought, ReAct and tree of thought.

Yoi shuumatsu wo (良い週末を): have a great weekend